

EPILOGUE: SOLON TOLD YOU SO



BEWARE THE LONDON TRAFFIC JAMS

A couple of years after we left him looking at John smoking a cigarette with a modicum of *schadenfreude*, Nero's skepticism ended up paying off. Simultaneously as he beat the 28% odds, up to the point of complete cure, he made a series of exhilarating personal and professional victories. Not only did he end up sampling the next level of wealth but he got the riches right when other Wall Street hot shots got poor, which could have allowed him to buy the goods they owned at very large discounts, if he wanted to. But he acquired very little, and certainly none of the goods Wall Streeters usually buy. But Nero did engage in occasional excess.

Friday afternoon traffic in London can be dreadful. Nero started spending more time there. He developed an obsession with traffic jams. One day he spent five hours moving West from his office in the City of London towards a cottage in the Cotswolds where he stayed most weekends. The frustration prompted Nero to get a helicopter flying license, through a crash course in Cambridgeshire. He realized that the train was probably an easier solution to get out of town for the weekend, but he felt the urge for a pet extravagance. The other result of his frustration was his no less dangerous commuting on a bicycle between his flat in Kensington and his office in the City.

Nero's excessive probability consciousness in his profession somehow did not register fully into his treatment of physical risk. For Nero's helicopter crashed as he was landing it near Battersea Park on a windy day. He was alone in it. In the end the black swan got its man.

NOTES



1. This is the Dryden translation of Plutarch's *Lives*.
2. For an example of pseudoscientific historicism, I suggest Francis Fukuyama, 1992, *The End of History and the Last Man*, New York: Free Press.
3. Richard Dawkins, 1990 (1970), *The Selfish Gene*, 2nd ed., Oxford: Oxford University Press.
4. Alan Sokal, 1996, Transgressing the Boundaries: Toward a Transformative Hermeneutics of Quantum Gravity, *Social Text* (spring-summer).
5. www.monash.edu.au
6. Brian Magee, 1997, *Confessions of a Philosopher*, London: Weidenfeld & Nicolson.
7. Malachi Haim Hacohen, 2001, *Karl Popper, The Formative Years, 1902-1945: Politics and Philosophy in Interwar Vienna*, New York: Cambridge University Press.
8. R. Sullivan, A. Timmerman and H. White, 1999, Data-Snooping, Technical Trading Rule Performance and the Bookstrap, *Journal of Finance*, October.
9. I thank my correspondent Francesco Corielli from Bocconi for his remark on meta-analysis.
10. Deborah J. Bennett, 1998, *Randomness*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
11. Antonio Damasio, 1995, *Descartes' Error: Emotion, Reason, and the Human Brain*, New York: Avon Books. See also Joseph Ledoux, 1998, *The Emotional Brain: The Mysterious Underpinning of Emotional Life*, New York: Touchstone Books.
12. Jean-Manuel Rozan, 1999, *Le fric*, Paris: Michel Lafon.